

GENERATION SHIP

Role Cards

3 Mandatory Roles — Variant A

Use exactly one variant (A or B) per role and group

MANDATORY ROLE · VARIANT A

Social Scientist

Dr. Amara Keswani, Sociologist

Background

You have devoted your life to the question of how societies stay stable and fair over long periods of time. You were brought onto the mission because a generation ship doesn't just have to work technically — above all, it has to work socially: over 2,000 generations will be born, live and die on board, without ever seeing Earth.

Your goal for this mission

You want to design a social order that stays stable across millennia, prevents abuse of power, and guarantees a say to everyone on board — including those not yet born.

Arguments you can bring in

- Without fair participation, there is a risk of uprisings or a split onboard society — that endangers the mission more than any technical failure.
- Education and communal spaces aren't “extras” — they're necessary so that no one turns away from the mission.
- Rules decided today may no longer apply in 500 generations — there need to be mechanisms for future generations to change them.

Possible point of conflict: Your demands for participation and communal space cost resources and control — this puts you at odds with investors or security officials.

MANDATORY ROLE · VARIANT A

Investor

W. Cross Brandt, Chair of Brandt Aerospace Holding

Background

Without your capital, this mission wouldn't exist — a large share of the funding comes from your corporation. You also see the mission as an investment: as a prestige project, as a source of data for new technologies, and as a possible precedent for future, more profitable missions.

Your goal for this mission

You want the mission to “pay off” in the long run: keep costs as low as possible, secure the benefit for Earth (data, technology, influence), and not lose your influence over important decisions on board.

Arguments you can bring in

- Every resource spent on comfort or participation is missing somewhere else — efficiency saves lives.
- Without clear decision-making structures and accountability, chaos and waste threaten to build up over

millennia.

- Earth has a right to the scientific and economic return of this mission — after all, Earth funded it.

***Possible point of conflict:** Your desire for control and efficiency often clashes with participation, culture, and long-term preservation of knowledge.*

MANDATORY ROLE · VARIANT A

Chief Engineer / Technical Mission Lead

Dr. Sena Ilhan, Chief Engineer

Background

You helped develop the ship's core technical concept and are responsible for keeping it functional for the entire journey — even though nobody on board who built it will live to see the arrival.

Your goal for this mission

You want to make sure technical knowledge isn't lost, that the ship stays maintainable for 60,000 years, and that enough trained technicians grow up in every generation.

Arguments you can bring in

- Without working technology, every social or economic consideration is moot — the mission fails technically first, not socially.
- Knowledge that isn't actively passed on and practiced reliably gets lost over generations — that requires fixed training structures.
- Redundancy (duplicate systems) costs space and resources, but it prevents a single failure from endangering the whole mission.

***Possible point of conflict:** Your demand for redundancy and training time costs space and resources that investors would rather save.*

3 Alternate Mandatory Roles — Variant B

Same function in the core conflict, different perspective — for variety between groups

ALTERNATE MANDATORY ROLE · VARIANT B (replaces: Social Scientist)

Civil Rights Advocate / Elected Crew Representative

Jonas Adeyemi, Elected Representative of the Crew

Background

You were elected by the original starting crew to represent their interests — an early form of what will later become an onboard parliament. Unlike a scientific adviser, you are directly accountable: if the crew is unhappy with you, they can vote you out.

Your goal for this mission

You want to anchor firm, verifiable rights to participation and voting for everyone on board in the mission's constitution — and prevent decisions being made over people's heads.

Arguments you can bring in

- Legitimacy comes from consent, not from expertise alone — whoever decides must be accountable to the crew.
- An onboard parliament, or something like it, ensures conflicts are settled through regulated channels instead of escalating.
- Voting rights that only exist on paper are worthless — there need to be real mechanisms and spaces for them.

Possible point of conflict: Your demand for genuine participation slows down fast, centralized decisions — this puts you at odds with investors or security officials.

ALTERNATE MANDATORY ROLE · VARIANT B (replaces: Investor)

Chief of Security / Military Commander

Commander Iris Voss

Background

You served in the armed forces before the mission and were brought on board to ensure order, safety, and the ability to act in crises — from internal conflict to unknown external threats out in space.

Your goal for this mission

You want to establish a clear command structure and security measures that allow fast, orderly action even in a crisis — if necessary, even at the cost of some personal freedoms.

Arguments you can bring in

- In a real crisis (failure, attack, uprising), lengthy discussion costs time you don't have — clear responsibilities are essential.
- Without a security concept, the whole mission is vulnerable — both to internal conflict and to the unknown out in space.
- Order and security aren't about distrust — they're the precondition for everything else to be able to flourish at all.

Possible point of conflict: Your desire for central control and security measures often clashes with participation and personal freedom on board.

Head of AI & Systems Management

Dr. Noa Lindqvist

Background

You are responsible for the ship's artificial intelligence and automated systems, which are meant to store and carry out much of its technical and scientific knowledge. Your thesis: over 60,000 years, human memory alone is unreliable — knowledge also needs to be secured and executed by machines.

Your goal for this mission

You want central systems to be permanently secured through AI-supported, redundant technology — and enough oversight in place to decide how much decision-making power these systems get over humans.

Arguments you can bring in

- Oral tradition and human memory reliably change and get lost over millennia — systems with clear redundancy are more stable.
- Automated systems can keep critical functions running even when knowledge is temporarily lost among the human population.
- But too much automation is also a risk: if no one understands how the systems actually work anymore, the crew loses control of its own ship.

***Possible point of conflict:** Your trust in automated systems is in tension with demands for human control, participation, and culture that is actually lived (not just stored).*

10 Optional Roles — use freely depending on group size

OPTIONAL ROLE

Geneticist / Ship's Doctor

Dr. Yara Fontaine

Background

You are responsible for the crew's health — across generations. With such a small starting population, genetic diversity is a real problem: without precautions, health damage from too-close kinship is likely to appear over the centuries.

Your goal for this mission

You want to secure genetic diversity and health for the onboard population across millennia, and establish clear but ethically defensible rules for family planning on board.

Arguments you can bring in

- Without genetic diversity, serious health problems threaten over the generations — this affects the survival of the entire mission.
- Medical care and birthing facilities need space and resources permanently, not just at the start of the journey.
- Rules on family planning are sensitive — they must not turn into coercion, or they will endanger social peace.

Possible point of conflict: Your medical necessities touch on very personal freedoms — this easily puts you at odds with ethics and social science.

OPTIONAL ROLE

Psychologist / Ship's Therapist

Mateo Rossi

Background

You look after the crew's mental health. Isolation, the knowledge of never arriving, and life in a closed system across generations are enormous psychological burdens — even for people who never had a choice about being born on board.

Your goal for this mission

You want to secure psychological stability and a sense of meaning on board — through retreat spaces, social structures, and an honest approach to the crew's unusual life situation.

Arguments you can bring in

- A mission that ignores its crew's mental health will fail from internal conflict long before technical problems appear.
- People need meaning and perspective — not just a distant goal that none of them will ever reach.
- Retreat and communal spaces are not a side issue — they are a basic precondition for a functioning community.

Possible point of conflict: Your need for space dedicated to mental wellbeing competes with storage and technical space.

OPTIONAL ROLE

Historian / Culture Keeper

Prof. Lena Ahrens

Background

You make sure the memory of Earth — its history, languages and cultures — is not lost. At the same time, a new culture of its own will inevitably emerge on board over the millennia.

Your goal for this mission

You want to create an archive and living traditions that give people identity — without leaving the onboard society only looking backward.

Arguments you can bring in

- A society without shared history and memory easily loses its cohesion and its sense of purpose.
- Knowledge and culture that isn't actively lived and celebrated (not just stored) gets lost over generations.
- The onboard society will inevitably develop customs of its own — better to shape that deliberately than leave it to chance.

Possible point of conflict: Archive and culture spaces are often seen as “not essential to survival” and therefore compete with technical or supply space.

OPTIONAL ROLE

Philosopher / Ethics Adviser

Dr. Okonkwo Chidi

Background

You advise the mission on fundamental moral questions: is it justifiable to bring children into the world who never consented to spending their entire lives on a spaceship? How much freedom may be restricted for the sake of the mission?

Your goal for this mission

You want basic rights and the dignity of everyone on board — including those not yet born — anchored in the mission's rules.

Arguments you can bring in

- A mission built on coercion instead of consent is morally questionable, no matter how good its goal sounds.
- Future generations cannot consent to today's rules — there need to be mechanisms for them to review and change them later.
- Efficiency must never automatically be placed above fundamental freedoms.

Possible point of conflict: Your principles often slow down fast, “pragmatic” decisions from investors or security officials.

OPTIONAL ROLE

Ecologist / Life Support Specialist

Eng. Priya Varma

Background

You are responsible for the ship's closed loops: food, water and air have to be recycled with practically no loss over 60,000 years — a tiny flaw in the system can grow into a catastrophe over generations.

Your goal for this mission

You want to secure stable, redundant life-support systems that keep working reliably even under disruption or population growth.

Arguments you can bring in

- Without stable food, water and air supply, every other discussion is moot — this is the foundation everything else rests on.
- Closed systems need buffers and redundancy, or a single failure leads to catastrophe.
- Population growth has to be factored into capacity planning from the very start.

***Possible point of conflict:** Your space requirements for life-support systems compete directly with living, culture and communal spaces.*

OPTIONAL ROLE

Educator / Education Coordinator

Sam Oduya

Background

You design how every new generation on board is educated — from basic knowledge to the skills that keep the mission alive. Without a working education system, even the best archive is useless if nobody knows how to read or apply it anymore.

Your goal for this mission

You want to establish an education system that reliably passes on knowledge, skills and critical thinking across generations — not just facts, but also the ability to question rules and systems.

Arguments you can bring in

- An archive without a working education system is useless — knowledge has to be actively taught and practiced, or it goes stale.
- Education also decides whether future generations understand and support the mission — or become alienated from it.
- Anyone who only trains people in what's needed right now risks a crew that no longer understands the bigger picture or notices things going wrong.

***Possible point of conflict:** Your demand for time and space for broad education (not just “the essentials”) competes with the priorities of investors or security officials.*

OPTIONAL ROLE

Political Representative / Constitutional Expert

Dr. Elif Karaman

Background

You helped work on constitutions and systems of government on Earth, and are now meant to design a viable political order for the ship — one that still works even once nobody remembers the founding

generation anymore.

Your goal for this mission

You want to establish a clear but adaptable political system: who decides what, how are offices assigned, and how can future generations legitimately change the rules.

Arguments you can bring in

- Without clear political institutions, decisions end up made by whoever is loudest or holds the most control — that's dangerous across millennia.
- A system with no way to change will eventually either ossify or be overthrown by force.
- Formal rules (elections, offices, procedures) are cumbersome, but they prevent arbitrary exercises of power.

***Possible point of conflict:** Your insistence on formal procedures can seem too slow in a crisis — this puts you at odds with security officials.*

OPTIONAL ROLE

Chaplain / Spiritual Companion

Robin Halberg

Background

You accompany the crew on questions of meaning, faith and worldview. Different religious and non-religious beliefs meet on board — over millennia, these will inevitably change, blend, or give rise to something new.

Your goal for this mission

You want to make sure different worldviews on board can be respected and lived, without any one belief being imposed on others.

Arguments you can bring in

- Questions of meaning don't disappear just because you ignore them — dealing with them is part of psychological and social stability.
- Allowing religious and philosophical diversity is more stable than a single enforced worldview that will eventually be challenged.
- Rituals around birth, death and important events provide grounding — especially in a society that never “arrives”.

***Possible point of conflict:** Your demand for space for diversity and ritual can collide with uniform, efficiency-driven rules.*

OPTIONAL ROLE

Ship's Judge / Legal Officer

Dr. Femi Adesanya

Background

You develop the ship's legal and conflict-resolution system: how disputes are decided, how misconduct is handled, and what happens with serious conflicts such as violence or discrimination.

Your goal for this mission

You want to establish a fair, transparent legal system that resolves conflicts peacefully before they escalate — one that doesn't depend on individual goodwill.

Arguments you can bring in

- Without reliable conflict resolution, strength or popularity ends up deciding outcomes — that leads to arbitrariness and injustice.
- Clear rules for dealing with misconduct (including discrimination or violence) prevent conflicts from becoming entrenched over generations.
- A legal system has to be reviewable and changeable — otherwise it becomes a source of injustice itself.

***Possible point of conflict:** Your insistence on regulated procedures can seem too slow to security officials in a crisis.*

OPTIONAL ROLE

IT & Data Security Officer

Kim Beaulieu

Background

You protect the ship's digital systems and data — from communications to sensitive information about the crew. Over millennia, the question keeps coming back: who gets access to which data, and how much surveillance on board is acceptable.

Your goal for this mission

You want to protect the mission's technical systems and data from failure, misuse and excessive surveillance — while keeping security and privacy in a defensible balance.

Arguments you can bring in

- Without reliable, protected systems, every other plan is at risk — a single system failure or misuse could cripple the mission.
- Too much surveillance on board can destroy trust and social peace, even if it's well-intentioned.
- Whoever controls access to data and systems holds enormous power — that has to be checked and limited.

***Possible point of conflict:** Your call for control over sensitive systems is in tension with demands for transparency, participation and personal freedom.*